moment remained typically fleeting because there was no sustained follow-up action to alleviate agrarian distress.

I met Kalavati a few years later when an NGO brought her to Delhi for a ‘guided tour’. It was almost as though she had become a ‘mascot’ for Vidarbha’s plight. Had her life changed, I asked. She nodded her head in a manner that suggested there hadn’t been any dramatic transformation. Had she met Rahul Gandhi? More silence. Did she trust politicians? She didn’t seem to want to answer. Kalavati’s story, in a sense, appeared to typify Rahul Gandhi’s politics—well intentioned but lacking the focus and stamina to convince the sceptics that he was a genuine 24/7 politician.

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On 24 September 2007, another famous chapter in Indian cricket was scripted when Mahendra Singh Dhoni’s team won the inaugural T20 World Cup, defeating Pakistan in the final. That win sparked the emergence of a new cricket hero in Dhoni. Rahul Gandhi perhaps was hoping for a similar political metamorphosis when on the same day he was anointed the Congress general secretary in charge of the Indian Youth Congress and the National Students’ Union of India (NSUI). While the rest of the country was celebrating the cricket triumph, Congressmen were rejoicing in the fact that Rahul Gandhi had finally decided to take up a specific political responsibility.

On the face of it, it wasn’t such a bad idea. The Youth Congress and NSUI were in desperate need of revival. The Congress was perceived as an ageing party in a ‘young’ country. Politics per se was seen as having no space for the youth even though 60 per cent of the population was under the age of thirty-five. As a young politician still in his thirties, Rahul Gandhi was, in a sense, ideally placed to effect a demographic shift in the Grand Old Party. If he could inspire the young to join politics, he was assured of a dedicated vote bank that would cut across traditional caste and community divisions. The last time a Congressman had attempted to build the Youth Congress was when Sanjay Gandhi took over the organization in the 1970s,